



SixthSense in Digit

For a better understand of Pranav Mistry's SixthSense, flip to page 46 of the May 2009 issue of Digit

Mr. Splashy Pants

Alexis Ohanian, co-founder of Reddit spoke about how the user community campaigned to name a Greenpeace blue whale

Feature



Indian aesthetics and values are shaping and giving rise to new ideas and trends in the fields of technology and design – cheap, eco-friendly, and for those at the bottom of the income pyramid

TED Tribe comes to India

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An international clique of 40 highly accomplished boffins, raconteurs, artists, and technocrats assembled at the Infosys campus in Mysore on November 4th to give an 18-minute talk, which in all likelihood, was the speech of their lives.

The TED Talk format tries its best to be some kind of band-aid for a generation of Twitter-addled, fragmented minds, and has its own ten commandments, asking of its speakers not to trot out the usual marketing schtick – no sales pitches or selling from the stage, but to dream a great dream, and dazzle the

audience with something never seen or shared before.

With millions of viewers watching these translated talks over the internet, the ideas discussed at TED India will resonate throughout the world. Behind the scenes, though, it was at the TED U sessions, (kind of an open-mic session of shorter talks for upcoming speakers) where some incredibly innovative ideas were aired.

“The stories we tell ourselves define us and our potential,” said Shekhar Kapur, in his talk. It was Ramachandra Budihal, a ‘techno-heritage imagineer’ who captured the spirit of the event. “We don’t enter the future, we create it. And we create what we imagine,” he said.

TED’s popularity owes much to the zest and energy of its videos – a combination of rhetorical discourse, laptop-powered techno-wizardry, slides and visualisations that shatter popular myths with stats, counter-points and analysis. Wit is a prerequisite to be a TED superstar. statistician Hans Rosling, who gave the first talk at TED India is destined to be a classic. His software, Gapminder amazed Google so much that they purchased it after seeing it demoed at a TED conference in 2007.

The most popular videos to come out of this meme-plex include the Sixth Sense augmented reality demo by MIT whiz-kid Pranav Mistry. Steven Pinker’s lecture on the myth of violence that argues we’re living in the most peaceful time of our species’ existence, and Hans Rosling’s lecture, told in the style of a TV weatherman that narrates how the whole of humanity, the third world included, is getting more educated, rising out of poverty, and seeing greater life expectancy.